A limited tale told clearly has more impact than a sweeping story that lacks depth and insight. The more frequently magazines and newspapers cover a given topic, the sharper and fresher the angle must be. Sidebar 3.1 provides examples of how to narrow the angle of some broad and unfocused topics.

SIDEBAR 3.1

How to Give a Tighter Angle to a Broad Topic

Too Broad	Tighter Angle
Losing Weight	Teacher Tells How She Lost 100 Pounds
Quitting Smoking	Can Hypnotism Help You Quit the Habit?
Improving Your Home's Security	An Ex-Burglar Tells How to Burglar-Proof Your Home
Traveling on a Budget	Five Ways to Find Cheap Hotels and Overnight Lodging
Choosing a Smartphone	Don't Buy These Extra Features You Don't Need in a Smartphone

The angle tree

One of the best ways to focus an idea is to use the "angle tree" exercise, which allows you to brainstorm on paper. Start with a broad topic you are interested in covering and write it in a center circle (as shown in Figure 3.1). Then write down four directions or angles you could pursue with that topic. If you try to cover all angles, your article will lack depth; however, you can choose one angle as your main focus and a second angle to explore as a sidebar. After you've decided on your focus, the next step is to determine whom you should interview and what kind of background research you should do.

CHARACTERISTICS OF A FOCUSED ANGLE

A focused angle has unity, action and concreteness. Unity means everything hangs together around a central idea. This central idea creates an

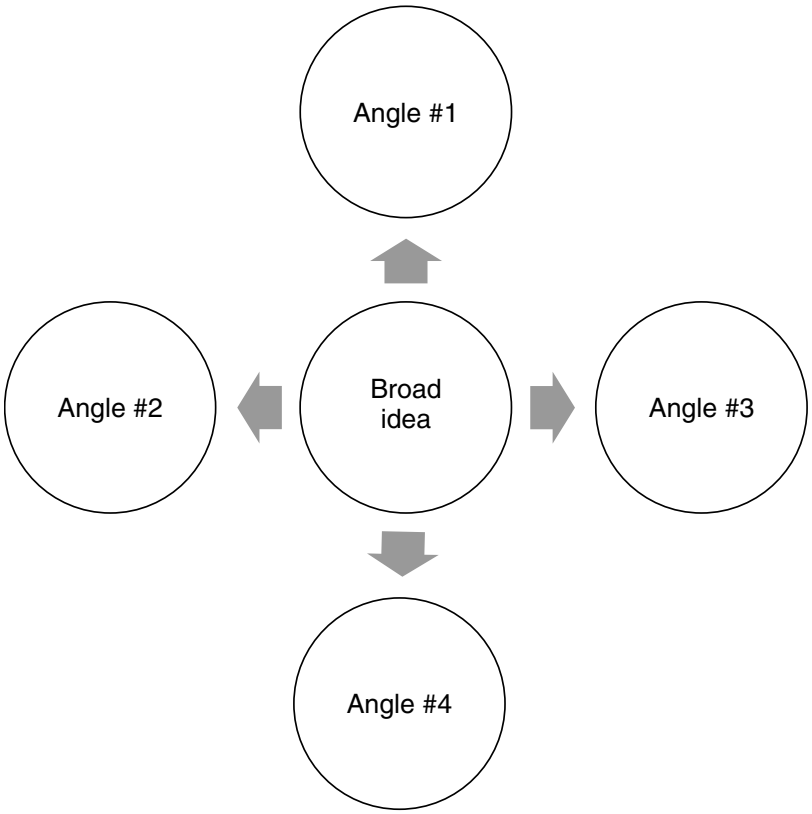


Figure 3.1 This "angle tree" illustrates how to take a broad idea and break it down into four angles.

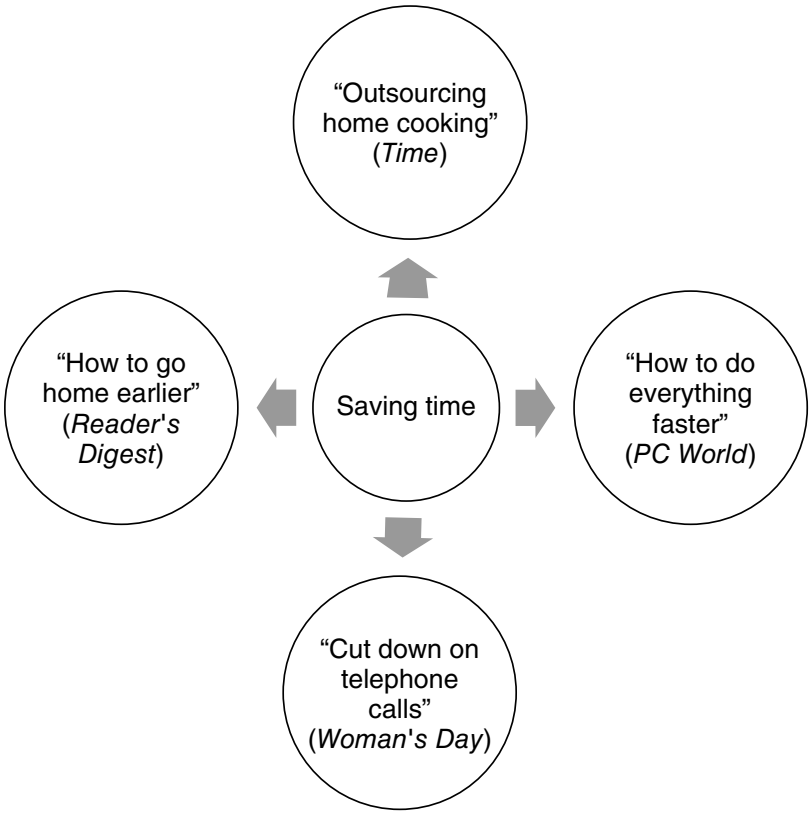


Figure 3.2 This is an example of four angles developed from the broad idea of time management. We chose some real titles that have been published in well-known magazines.